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List of longest diaries

This is a list of diaries notable for their exceptional length, primarily by word count but also by duration.

Table of diaries sortable by word count and duration

Author	Word count	Duration	Period	Notes
Laura Penrose Francis ^[1]	40 million	60 years	1952–2012	Word count and duration as of 2012. ^[2]
<u>Robert Shields</u>	37.5 million	25 years	1972–1997	Exact word count not available until 2049. ^[3]
<u>Claude Fredericks</u>	30 million	80 years	1932–2013	Word count is estimated; the manuscript runs to 65,000 pages. ^[4]
Joseph Holloway	25 million	45 years	1899–1944	"Dublin playgoer." Published diaries 1899 to 1944. ^[5] ^[6]
<u>Edward Robb Ellis</u>	22 million	71 years	1927–1998	
<u>Tony Benn</u>	20 million ^[7]	69 years	1940–2009	A better estimate is 15.7m. "The full unedited diaries [in 2007] amount to around fifteen million words." ^[8]
Heinrich Witt	18 million	70 years	1859–1890	Witt (1799–1892) was born in Germany, lived in Peru, and wrote in English. ^[9]
<u>Arthur Crew Inman</u>	17 million	44 years	1919–1963	155 volumes. ^[10] Other accounts state 10 million words. ^[11]
<u>Nella Last</u>	12 million ^[12]	28 years	1939–1967	Participant in <u>Mass Observation</u> project.
Dr. John Henry Salter	10 million	83 years	1849–1932	GP of Tolleshunt D'Arcy, Essex. ^[13]
<u>Henri-Frédéric Amiel</u>	6 million	42 years	1839–1881	173 journals; 16,800 pages. ^[14]
Ellsworth James	5.9 million	63 years	1944–2007	Word count does not include first year (1944) which was handwritten. 1946-2007 manually typed. ^[15]
John Gadd	4 million	45 years	1975–2020	Started in 1947 ^[16] but kept consistently from 1975. ^[17]
George C. Edler	2.859 million	80 years	1907–1987	76 volumes. ^[18] 1987 and 1988 <i>Guinness Book of World Records</i> has different dates.
<u>Henry David Thoreau</u>	2 million	25 years	1837–1861	Over 2 million words in 39 notebooks. ^[19] ^[20]
<u>Beatrice Webb</u>	1.79 million	70 years	1873–1943	Diaries available online. ^[21]
<u>Samuel Pepys</u>	1.25 million	9 years	1660–1669	Written in shorthand. ^[22] The 1893 edition is available online. ^[23]
<u>Margaret Elizabeth Fountaine</u>	1 million	61 years	1878–1939	12 volume diary. ^[24]
<u>Jean Lucey Pratt</u>	1 million	61 years	1925–1986	Over a million words in 45 exercise books. ^[25]
<u>Ernest Achey Loftus</u>	Unknown	91 years	1896–1987	<u>Guinness World Record</u> for longest kept diary. ^[26] ^[27]
Evie Riski	Unknown	90 years	1936–2025	"A 100-year-old American woman has journalled every day for 90 years... nearly 33,000 entries..." ^[28]

<u>Caroline Bray</u>	Unknown	87 years	1815–1902	Née Hennell; she was the intimate friend of <u>George Eliot</u> . Diary and commonplace book. ^[29]
Anne Perkins	Unknown	74 years	1935–2009	Kept a diary beginning at the age of ten, and wrote over a hundred volumes. Sixteen volumes are held at <u>Swarthmore College</u> , where she worked as a librarian. ^[30]
<u>Claude Mauriac</u>	Unknown	69 years	1927–1995	Lejeune gives both 68 and 69 years. "We have yet to count the total number of pages, but the journal measures three and a half meters." ^[31]
Sanjōnishi Sanetaka	Unknown	62 years ^[32]	1455–1537	His <i>Sanetaka Kōki</i> is also given a duration of 63 years. ^[33]
<u>William Lyon Mackenzie King</u>	Unknown	57 years	1893–1950	Word count not stated; the manuscript exceeds 50,000 pages. ^[34]

William Matthews, in his *British diaries: An annotated bibliography of British diaries written between 1442 and 1942* (University of California Press, Berkeley and Los Angeles, 1950) lists 400 diaries with a duration of 30 years or more.

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